

SHOW ME THE RECEIPTS

The Receipts the Donor Can See

FRONT SIDE

MARKETING & FIRST CONTACT

- The case for support — every claim is a promise
- Website content (current, accurate, consistent)
- Online giving page user experience
- Direct mail and email appeals
- Cold call scripts and tone
- Event invitations
- Social media presence
- Email signatures, links, and staff bios
- Press releases and media coverage
- Annual report claims
- Newsletter content and frequency
- Brand consistency across channels

THE ASK

- Cultivation moves leading up to the ask
- The pre-ask site visit or experience
- Spoken promises during the visit
- The written proposal (specifics, deadlines)
- The gift agreement (terms, restrictions, naming)
- Pledge cards and pledge documentation
- Naming opportunity language
- Recognition options presented at the ask
- Matching gift commitments
- Recognition tier descriptions
- The "if you give X, we will Y" promises

ACKNOWLEDGMENT

- Letter timing (within stated window)
- Letter accuracy (amount, designation, salutation)
- Tax receipt with correct IRS language
- Personal thank-you call from the right person
- Phone acknowledgment within the stated window
- Handwritten note from leadership
- Multi-touch thank-you sequence
- Social media acknowledgment (with permission)
- Acknowledgment from a beneficiary (if promised)

RECOGNITION

- Donor wall placement (correct names, levels, spelling)
- Plaques, dedications, named spaces
- Annual report donor listing
- Newsletter and event-program recognition
- Recognition society or giving-circle membership
- Member-exclusive events and access
- Lifetime giving milestones
- Anniversary recognitions (10-year, 25-year)
- Memorial and tribute gift acknowledgments

STEWARDSHIP COMMUNICATIONS

- Impact reports delivered as promised
- Site visits and tours
- Behind-the-scenes access
- Personal updates from the ED or program lead
- Birthday, anniversary, holiday cards
- Year-end greeting from board chair or leadership
- Condolence and life-event acknowledgments
- Annual giving statements
- Survey responses honored and acted on
- "Just thinking of you" non-ask touches

FRONT-FACING PROMISES

- "I'll get back to you by Friday"
- "I'll send the proposal Tuesday"
- "The ED will call you next week"
- Calendar holds and meeting confirmations
- Promises about who will be at the meeting
- Promises about what will be discussed
- Promises about what comes after
- Promises about confidentiality and discretion
- The promise to listen, not just to ask
- Promises kept in the donor's living room

EVENT EXPERIENCES

- Invitations to the right donors on time
- Pre-event communication and reminders
- Event quality matching the case for support
- Recognition delivered as promised on stage
- Speech content honoring donor intent
- Photo and follow-up after the event
- Donor's table experience (seating, hosts)

RE-SOLICITATION

- The next ask framed by the last gift
- Pledge payment reminders accurate, on time
- Multi-year commitment conversations
- Renewal letters honoring giving history
- Upgrade asks based on relationship
- Lapsed donor outreach respecting history

"Today's problems come from yesterday's 'solutions.'"

— Peter Senge, The Fifth Discipline



SCAN

Full inventory • Trust Audit worksheet • Session resources

ShowMeReceipts.org

Trust is what the receipts add up to.

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CHAPTER PROGRAM
JUNE 2026

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BACK SIDE

DATA INTEGRITY

- Accurate name and salutation as the donor uses them
- Spouse, family, household information current
- Communication-preference flags honored
- Channel preferences (mail / email / phone)
- Giving history logged accurately, all gifts visible
- Designation and restriction tracking end-to-end
- Soft credits and matching-gift attribution preserved
- Tribute and memorial designations honored
- Pledge balance accuracy across systems
- Privacy and confidentiality protocols enforced
- Database hygiene (duplicates, decedents, opt-outs)
- Wealth-screening data current and reviewed
- Capacity and affinity ratings updated
- Propensity scores recalculated regularly
- Address standardization and NCOA updates
- Email deliverability and bounce management
- Custom fields populated, queryable, consistent
- Data backup, recovery, and access controls

GIFT PROCESSING

- Gifts received and recorded within standard hours
- Funds deposited to designated accounts
- Restricted-fund designation respected end-to-end
- IRS substantiation language on every gift over \$250
- Pledge tracking and payment reminders on schedule
- Stock, planned, and complex gift handling
- Reconciliation between development and finance
- Recurring gift management (failed cards, expirations)
- Payment gateway uptime and security
- PCI compliance for credit card processing
- Quid-pro-quo disclosure on premium-benefit gifts
- In-kind gift valuation and acknowledgment
- Anonymous gift handling protocols
- Refund and gift-correction processes

INTERNAL HANDOFFS

- Development to program (purpose, deliverable)
- Development to finance (deposits, books, audit)
- Development to communications (correct donor, level)
- Development to leadership (briefings before visits)
- Front-facing director to operations
- Operations to vendors (contractor, engraver, printer)
- Major gifts to annual fund (no double-asking)
- Annual fund to capital campaign coordination
- Development to events (the donor's gala experience)
- Outgoing staff to incoming staff (continuity)
- Department to department on shared donors
- Frontline to back-office (call notes, action items)
- Volunteer leadership to staff (commitments made)
- Board to staff (gift expectations, asks)

TIMING COMMITMENTS

- Acknowledgment within stated window (24–48 hrs)
- Follow-up after every donor meeting
- Pledge reminders sent on schedule
- Reports delivered when promised
- Tax receipts issued before January 31
- Site visits scheduled within reasonable windows
- Meeting confirmations sent in advance
- Calendar holds honored, not double-booked
- Response time to donor inquiries
- Year-end giving deadline communicated
- Stewardship calendar touchpoints honored
- Fiscal year-end close on schedule
- Annual report production deadline

COMPLIANCE & REPORTING

- Form 990 filed on time and complete
- State charitable registrations renewed in every state
- Form 8283 for non-cash gifts over \$5,000
- Quid-pro-quo disclosure on premium gifts
- Audit trail for every restricted disbursement
- Conflict-of-interest disclosures current
- Whistleblower and document retention policies
- Public charity status maintained
- Lobbying limits tracked (501(h) when applicable)
- Annual independent audit completed

PROCESS & WORKFLOW

- Cultivation moves logged and queued
- Solicitation calendar respected (no over-asking)
- Renewal cycles tracked
- Proposal drafts reviewed before delivery
- Stewardship plans documented and assigned
- Moves management entries kept current
- Next-action prompts honored on time
- Portfolio reviews conducted regularly
- Major-gift pipeline meetings held
- Activity logging for every donor touch
- Cross-checking spelling on plaques, walls, programs
- Prospect qualification protocols followed

MISSION—MONEY ALIGNMENT

- Restricted funds spent on restricted purpose
- Budget reflects donor commitments
- Strategic plan honors campaign promises
- Programmatic priorities match what we said
- Audit and 990 truthfully represent the work
- Endowment policy honored (spending, investment)
- Net asset classifications maintained
- Functional expense allocation accurate
- Gift acceptance policy applied consistently

DIGITAL INFRASTRUCTURE

- Website uptime and security
- Donation form availability across browsers
- Email deliverability and sender reputation
- SSL certificates current
- Privacy policy posted and accurate
- Database access controls and authentication
- Spam compliance (CAN-SPAM, GDPR if applicable)
- Mobile responsiveness of digital touchpoints

BENEFICIARY STEWARDSHIP

- Programs deliver on case-for-support promises
- Outcomes measured against what was promised
- Beneficiary stories shared with permission
- Beneficiary dignity preserved in donor comms
- Equity commitments honored in delivery

BOARD & LEADERSHIP

- Board members fulfill giving and asking commitments
- ED keeps stewardship promises (calls, visits)
- Board governance receipts (oversight, accountability)
- Volunteer engagement and recognition
- Culture of philanthropy modeled at the top
- Succession planning for leadership transitions

VENDORS & PARTNERS

- Database vendor (uptime, security, support)
- Auditor (timely, accurate, candid)
- Printer (quality, deadline, accuracy on names)
- Legal counsel (gift agreement, tax compliance)
- Investment manager (performance, reporting)
- Payment processor (uptime, fees, security)
- Wealth screening provider (data, privacy)

“Cause and effect are not closely related in time and space.”

— Peter Senge, *The Fifth Discipline*



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Make a promise. Keep it. Make another. Keep it.

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